

Constituents American ginseng contains steroidal saponins, including panaquilon.

History & Folklore Native American peoples may have considered this herb a means to increase female fertility. From the mid-18th century, the collection of the herb for export to China became a virtual goldrush, with so many Native Americans out harvesting American ginseng that settlers reported finding villages almost deserted. The Ojibwa people always planted a seed to replace the herb, but this was not universal practice. American ginseng became rare toward the end of the 19th century.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The action of American ginseng is presumed to be similar to, but milder than, that of its Chinese cousin, ginseng (*P. ginseng*, p. 118). American ginseng increases the ability to tolerate stress of all kinds. In traditional Chinese medicine, American ginseng is employed as a yin tonic, treating weakness, fever, wheezing, and coughs.

Related Species See ginseng, nototginseng (*P. notoginseng*, preceding entry), and Siberian ginseng (*Eleutherococcus senticosus*, p. 94).

Caution Do not take American ginseng during pregnancy.

Papaver rhoeas (Papaveraceae) Red Poppy

Description Delicate hairy-stemmed annual growing to 3 ft (90 cm). Has basal rosette of lance-shaped leaves and deeply incised stem leaves, 4-petaled red flowers with black anthers, and small rounded seed capsules.

Habitat & Cultivation Red poppy is native to Europe, North Africa, and temperate regions of Asia, and is naturalized in North and South America. It thrives on cultivated land and on road verges. The flowers are picked in summer.

Parts Used Flowers.

Constituents Red poppy contains alkaloids (including papaverine, rhoeadine, isorhoeadine, and many others), meconic acid, mekocyanin, mucilage, and tannin. The alkaloids are similar to those in the opium poppy (*P. somniferum*, see following entry), but are much milder.

History & Folklore According to Agnus Castus, writing in the 14th century, "If a man have ony payne aboutyn his eyne or if a man have a mygreyn tak this herb and stamp it and nedle it with oyle de olywe and anynt ther-with the forhed and it schal amende the syth and slake the payne and distroye the mygreyn."

Medicinal Actions & Uses Red poppy flowers are mildly analgesic and sedative, and have long been used in European herbal medicine, particularly for ailments in children and the elderly.

Chiefly employed as a mild pain reliever and as a treatment for irritable coughs, red poppy also helps reduce nervous overactivity. The herb may be used in the treatment of insomnia, general irritability, coughs—especially paroxysmal coughs—and asthma, and is generally given as a syrup.

Related Species See also opium poppy (*P. somniferum*, following entry), Mexican poppy (*Argemone mexicana*, p. 171), and California poppy (*Eschscholzia californica*, p. 207).

⚠ Cautions Use only under professional supervision. All parts of red poppy except the seeds are potentially toxic if eaten.

Papaver somniferum (Papaveraceae)

Opium Poppy

Description Thick-stemmed annual growing to about 3 ft (1 m). Has many dull green leaves, solitary pink, purple or white flowers, and globe-shaped seed capsules.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to western Asia, opium poppy is now cultivated commercially around the world as the source of morphine and codeine, and as an illegal crop for the production of opium and heroin. During the summer, the seed capsules are cut and the white latex that exudes is gathered the next day and dried.

Part Used Latex.

Constituents Opium poppy contains more than 40 opium alkaloids, including morphine (up to 20%), narcotine (about 5%), codeine (about 1%), and papaverine (about 1%). It also contains meconic acid, albumin, mucilage, sugars, resin, and wax. Many of the opium poppy's alkaloids have a well-established therapeutic action. Morphine is one of the most powerful analgesics of all, used extensively in conventional medicine to relieve pain, especially in terminal illness. Codeine is a milder analgesic used for headaches and other pain, and in the symptomatic treatment of diarrhea. Opium's strongly addictive nature is well established.

History & Folklore Cultivated for its medicinal properties for at least 4,000 years, the opium poppy was introduced to Greece about 3,000 years ago, and from there spread throughout Europe. It was unknown in China until the 7th century CE, and in Japan until the 15th century. It is mentioned in the Assyrian herbals (c. 1700 BCE), and the Greek physician Dioscorides (40–90 CE) wrote that "a decoction of the leaves and flowerheads if drunk and bathed on the head is unrivaled in inducing sleep. The mashed heads, mixed with flour, make a useful plaster in inflammations and St. Anthony's fire [erysipelas, a bacterial infection of the skin]."

Medicinal Actions & Uses Opium (the dried latex) is a potent narcotic, analgesic, and antispasmodic, and has been taken to relieve pain of various kinds. In all the main herbal traditions it is regarded as a powerfully "cold" remedy, reducing physical function and sedating or suppressing nervous activity, pain, and coughs. In view of its addictive nature, opium is mainly used after other less powerful analgesics have failed to bring relief. It is also an effective remedy for acute diarrhea and severe coughs. Pharmaceutical drugs produced from opium poppy include morphine and codeine.

Research Much research has been done, confirming most of the uses of opium poppy listed above.

Related Species See also red poppy (*P. rhoeas*, preceding entry), Mexican poppy (*Argemone mexicana*, p. 171), and California poppy (*Eschscholzia californica*, p. 207).

⚠ Cautions Use opium poppy only under professional supervision. It is subject to legal restrictions in most countries.

